In Japan, by contrast, modernity and the concept of openness have always been restrained by a tradition of social stability and hierarchy that goes back to the seven centuries of a feudal system headed by shoguns and emperors. Generations of a social caste system left an impression after the abolishment of the last formal vestiges of feudalism in the mid-1870s, even as the Japanese took full advantage of the freedom to choose their livelihoods, marriage partners, and places of residence. In complex ways, the social residue of those centuries persists in contemporary Japan, symbolized at its apex by the emperor. Such is one explanation both for the perplexing endurance of the imperial system and the concomitant attention paid to the Heisei emperor's unprecedented wish to abdicate the throne in favor of his son, in 2019.

The Japanese imperial clan traces its lineage back to the seventh century, making it the world's oldest dynasty, if not monarchy. Pruned dramatically after the Second World War by the American occupying forces headed by General Douglas MacArthur, the institution remains at the spiritual core of Japan. Yet despite continued controversy over 1940s-era war guilt and the occasional divinity question, the decades of peaceful postwar history have dulled any serious opposition to its continued existence. There is no republican movement in Japan, nor calls to reduce the expenditures of the imperial family. With only three emperors in the last century, the clan quietly continues along, avoiding scandal and entering the spotlight only in the most controlled of environments. As patrons and scholars in their own right, Japan's royals have been model constitutional monarchs, with the extended family dutifully performing their functions, much like the vast majority of their subjects.

After a reign of three decades, the Heisei emperor (known during his reign as Emperor Akihito) became the first Japanese sovereign to abdicate in over two centuries when he stepped down in April 2019. In an August 2016 television address, Akihito, then in the twenty-eighth year of his reign, made clear his desire to abdicate in favor of his son, Crown Prince Naruhito, because of his advanced age (eighty-two) and his poor health (he had undergone heart surgery and recovered from